

UNDERCOVER GAMES

India hosts the Military World Games, the biggest sports event after the Olympics, but stifling security and overzealous organisers ensure that the event is off limits for the ordinary fan



OUT OF BOUNDS:
Security personnel
outside Games venue

■ **By Amarnath K. Menon**

It was billed as the biggest sports event India had ever seen. The Military World Games (MWG) were headed to Asia for the first time, to be hosted by Hyderabad and Mumbai. The numbers put out by the Indian organisers were certainly impressive. The MWG were to feature 4,588 athletes, including 818 women, from 103 participating nations competing over 15 disciplines.

The athletes were servicemen and women from all over the world gathering for their quadrennial sports festival under the banner of the Brussels-based Conseil International du Sport Militaire (CISM). With 128 member nations, CISM is the world's second-largest sporting body after the International Olympic Committee (IOC). Naturally MWG, held the year before every Olympics, is second only to the

mother of all sporting events in terms of size, even if not in lustre. So when the fourth MWG came to India, it was expected that the land known for its love of the spectacle would finally provide the Games the platform they deserved.

But as they began in Hyderabad, it was evident that these military games were not to be a joyous celebration of sport, but rather an extension of a grim military exercise conducted under a heavy blanket of security. It was an event of the military and by the military, and going by the restrictive rules of entry, very much for the military. The Indian armed forces, in keeping with their tradition of spit and polish, made everything spick, span and

shipshape but the stifling security arrangements robbed the Games of their popular appeal.

The event had been relentlessly promoted in Hyderabad through fashion shows and television commercials. But when the time came for the actual occasion, countless sports fans were left seething with disappointment. Most of the ordinary spectators were denied entry to the sporting arenas on the grounds of security of the athletes.

Even though President Pratibha Patil inaugurated the Games and armyman and Olympic medallist shooter Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore ignited a canon to light the flames of the Games, the opening ceremony

For every athlete at Military World Games, there were eight other people either on security or organisation duty.